The Kasaragod district police chief, meanwhile, said that his force had indeed received a missing person's complaint, traced the girl to Bengaluru, and that her statement had been recorded both by the police and a magistrate. District Police Chief James Joseph said 'no love jihad angle' was alleged by the girl or had come up in the investigation.[113] Karandlaje, on the other hand, alleged that three boys had been blackmailing the girl's family to convert to Islam, saying they would release the alleged rape video if the family refused to do so. She declared that such cases were happening regularly in the 'border areas with Kerala', and demanded a thorough investigation. After the Karnataka BJP took up the case, the Bangalore police registered a case and it was subsequently transferred to the Karnataka CID.[114] The political blame-game over the incident reflected how Karnataka politics was now leaching into Kerala, where the BJP believed it was growing. Karandlaje was also said to have later taken up the pro-CAA cause in the border areas in Kerala.

At the Bengaluru RSS headquarters, local workers told me that, by 2020, the Kerala RSS had more 'organisational growth than in the Gujarat chapter in terms of full-time workers'. As one worker put it, 'Our political growth is not there in Kerala so far in terms of victories but we have a political dividend there because we have shakha density.' Then why did the BJP not grow there as much as it did in Karnataka, I asked. 'Because in Kerala, Hindus are 53 per cent,' he responded. 'Muslims are 27 per cent, Christians are 18 per cent. That's why we have not grown and BJP has not grown as much.' Meanwhile, Karnataka has emerged as the springboard for RSS activities in Kerala. 'Most RSS pracharaks in Kerala are from Karnataka. We also send pracharaks for Northeast.'[115]

In Tamil Nadu, which remains divided between the DMK and the AIADMK, the BJP was relying on the support base of actor Rajinikanth and the often discussed possibility that he would launch a new party to create an opening through an anti-Periyar faultline. (Periyar, or Erode Venkatappa Ramasamy [1879–1973], is regarded as the father of the Dravidian Movement and started the Self-respect Movement and the Dravidar Kazhagam.) 'This has parallels with how Nehru was treated like a demigod by Congress,' said the journalist